Sourdough starter: 14-day cheat sheet

sourdough-science · notes/starter-cheatsheet.md · 2026-10-31

You need: a flour mix of 350 g bread flour + 150 g dark rye (30% rye), a straight-sided jar with a rubber band, a 0.1 g scale and 24°C. Cloth cover until day 8, then a loose lid.

Schedule — grams of starter / water / flour

Day	Morning	Evening	What you'll see
1	—	0 / 30 / 30	Mix only, rest 24 h
2	—	Stir, clean jar	Dry skin on top: fine
3	—	20 / 20 / 20	Risen: bacteria, not yeast yet
4	20 / 20 / 20	16 / 16 / 16	3–4×, runny, cheesy smell
5	15 / 15 / 15	16 / 16 / 16	**Almost no rise, vomit smell: normal**
6–7	15 / 15 / 15	15 / 15 / 15	1.2–2×, milder, first sour notes
8	15 / 15 / 15	15 / 15 / 15	~2×. Save discard, loose lid
9	15 / 15 / 15	8 / 16 / 16	2.5×
10	8 / 16 / 16	5 / 15 / 15	2.5×, falls before the feed
11	5 / 20 / 20	5 / 25 / 25	2.5×
12	5 / 25 / 25	5 / 20 / 20	Evening: switch to 10% rye mix
13	5 / 25 / 25	5 / 25 / 25	2.5×
14	8 / 16 / 16 ×2	10 / 50 / 50	Feeds 7 h apart; three a day now

Rules

- **Feed at peak:** fallen before the feed? Next feed one ratio up, 1:2:2 → 1:3:3 → 1:4:4 → 1:5:5. Domed: wait. Level, first wrinkles: now. Sunken, boozy: hours late.
- **Ratio by feeds a day** once it is strong, at 24–27°C: three 1:2:2 · two 1:4:4–1:5:5 · one 1:10:10. Held at 1:2:2 twice a day into week two, a good starter fades.
- **Away longer than its time to peak?** Up to 1.5×: one step up. About 2×, a working day: 1:10:10, or 1:5:5 somewhere cooler. Overnight: 1:10:10 cooler, or stiff, 1:6:10. 1–2 days: 1:5:5 into the fridge.
- **Day 12:** 10% rye mix = leftover 30% mix + twice its weight in bread flour.
- **Done** when it triples in 4–6 h on 1:2:2 at 27°C (oven, light on). Video's day 14: 3× in 7 h.
- **Discard** if pink, orange or fuzzy. **No 40°C+ builds** until done. Fridge: 2–4 weeks; left underfed there, 1:10:10 first.
- **Dried backup:** good pinch + 30 g water + 30 g wholemeal/rye; wait days; then as day 4.

Source: Full Proof Baking, 2019 · the long version: sourdough-science/notes/starter-from-scratch.md